

Chapter 1: *She Already Has a Best Friend*

She had always talked to Mia.

Not in the dramatic way people imagined when they heard things like that.

No whispers in mirrors. No trembling voices in empty rooms.

It was more ordinary than that.

Like asking someone sitting beside her what they thought about life choices.

Like complaining about the world and getting immediate commentary in return.

Like sharing silence that never really felt silent.

So when she graduated at forty, Mia was already there.

Waiting, as usual.

The ceremony ended with polite applause and carefully arranged smiles.

She stood with her certificate pressed against her chest, feeling like she had completed something important—but also like she had arrived late to her own celebration.

Around her, younger graduates hugged, screamed, took photos, jumped like their lives had just begun.

She smiled.

She did not jump.

“That was survivable,” Mia said beside her.

“It was emotional,” she corrected.

Mia made a face. “Same thing. Yours just comes with sweating.”

She exhaled a laugh.

“Can we take a picture?” she asked.

Mia immediately stepped behind her.

“No.”

She paused. “Why not?”

“Because I refuse to be captured in 2010 phone camera quality.”

“This is 2026.”

“Exactly. I deserve better resolution.”

She shook her head, smiling anyway, and took the picture alone.

It still felt like Mia was in it somehow.

She always did.

On the walk home, Mia complained about everything.

The weather.

The ceremony music.

The fact that someone had clapped off-beat during the speeches.

“You’re being dramatic,” she said.

“I am being *correct*,” Mia replied. “There’s a difference.”

She adjusted her bag strap. “I finally graduated.”

“I know,” Mia said. “I was there.”

“I mean—officially.”

Mia glanced at her. “Do you think official things make life more real?”

That made her quiet for a second.

Then she shrugged.

“I think they make it easier to explain to other people.”

Mia hummed. “Other people are overrated anyway.”

When she got home, she placed the certificate on the table like it might disappear if she didn’t supervise it.

Then she stood there.

Waiting.

For something.

She wasn’t sure what.

A call. A message. A feeling of transformation. Something cinematic.

Nothing happened.

Just the sound of the refrigerator humming like it had a stable career.

“You’re going to stare at it until it applies for jobs for you,” Mia said.

“I’m processing.”

“You’ve been processing since 2012.”

“That’s not fair.”

“It’s accurate.”

She finally sat down on the couch.

The silence in the apartment felt louder than the graduation applause.

“So what now?” she asked.

Mia didn’t answer immediately.

That was unusual.

Mia always answered immediately.

Finally, Mia said:

“Now you panic responsibly.”

She snorted. “That’s not advice.”

“It’s lifestyle management.”

That evening, she opened her laptop.

Job sites.

Empty tabs.

Requirements she already knew she wouldn’t meet.

Mia leaned over her shoulder.

“Don’t apply to that one,” Mia said.

“Why?”

“Because they use phrases like ‘fast-paced environment.’ That means unpaid overtime and emotional damage.”

She laughed. “You’re guessing.”

“I’m experienced.”

“In what?”

Mia smiled. “Surviving things I didn’t sign up for.”

That answer sat strangely in the room.

But she didn’t question it.

Not then.

At some point, she stood to make tea.

Mia followed her into the kitchen like she always did.

Naturally.

Without announcement.

Without hesitation.

Like she had never not been there.

“You know,” she said, stirring sugar into her cup, “sometimes I think I should have started earlier.”

“Earlier what?” Mia asked.

“Everything. School. Career. Life.”

Mia leaned against the counter.

“You started exactly when you could.”

She frowned. “That sounds comforting.”

“It’s not. It’s factual.”

She smiled slightly.

“That’s your version of kindness, isn’t it?”

Mia tilted her head. “Kindness is just honesty without unnecessary violence.”

“That’s... surprisingly wise.”

“I know. Try not to get emotional about it.”

Later that night, she sat on her bed with her laptop open, scrolling through old folders.

Certificates. Assignments. Random drafts of dreams she never finished.

Mia sat beside her.

Not touching anything.

Just there.

Comfortable.

Familiar.

“Do you remember when we almost gave up on this?” she asked quietly.

Mia didn’t hesitate.

“No,” Mia said.

Then added:

“Because we didn’t.”

She looked at Mia.

Something about that answer should have felt strange.

But it didn’t.

It just felt like relief.

Before she slept, she stared at the ceiling.

“I think I did okay today,” she said.

Mia hummed. “You didn’t cry in public. That’s growth.”

“That’s your metric?”

“It’s a good one.”

She smiled in the dark.

“Thanks for being here.”

Mia didn’t answer right away.

Then, softly:

“Always.”

And somewhere in the quiet of that sentence—

nothing felt wrong.

Not yet.

End of Chapter 1
